

Impact Studio in Collaboration with MUV
Exploring Market Entry Conditions for MUV in France
Focus Paper

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1. Context and Background

In the face of the climate emergency and the urgent need to reduce transport-related emissions, everyday mobility has become a key lever for transformation. Across Europe, public policies are increasingly encouraging more sustainable practices through cycling infrastructure, financial incentives, and regulatory obligations for employers.

A persistent gap, however, remains between structural ambitions and actual user behaviour. Infrastructure, on its own, fails to drive lasting behavioural change. Users are rarely involved in the design of mobility systems, leading to low ownership, limited continuity in usage, and reliance on short-term incentives.

MUV operates precisely within this context — an Italian startup that has developed a gamified application designed to encourage more sustainable mobility behaviours. The platform transforms everyday journeys into a collective game in which users earn points, join challenges, and compete individually or as part of a team. Its underlying ambition is to act on the social and motivational dimensions of mobility choices, treating behavioural change as a design problem, one that is social and motivational before anything else.

While MUV has been involved in occasional French initiatives — notably a mobility challenge with Université de Montpellier Paul-Valéry — its presence in France remains partial and fragmented. This project, conducted as part of the Impact Studio at Sciences Po between October 2025 and May 2026, was conceived to address this gap by clarifying the conditions under which a more structured and scalable French deployment could be envisaged.

2. Objectives

The central question driving this project was:

How can a solution like MUV integrate into a highly institutionalised mobility ecosystem while generating meaningful and sustained user engagement?

To address this, the project explored four subsidiary questions:

- What are the barriers and drivers for adopting a gamified mobility solution in France?
- How is the ecosystem of public actors, private stakeholders, and users structured?
- Why do existing initiatives struggle to generate long-term behavioural change?
- What strategic positioning would allow MUV to create value within this ecosystem?

The project addressed environmental impact (encouraging sustainable practices and reducing emissions), behavioural impact (fostering long-term habit change beyond short-term campaigns), and institutional impact (supporting public and private actors in achieving their CSR, carbon-reporting, and mobility-policy objectives).

3. Methodology

The project adopted a qualitative and systemic approach, combining four complementary methods.

3.1. Internal analysis of MUV

An in-depth analysis of MUV's model — including its value proposition, engagement mechanisms, and positioning at the intersection of technological innovation and behavioural design — was conducted alongside a user-experience review to identify friction points in onboarding and daily tracking.

3.2. Analysis of the French ecosystem

The French sustainable-mobility environment was mapped across three dimensions: regulatory frameworks (GDPR, ePrivacy, CSRD, Loi d'Orientation des Mobilités, Loi Climat et Résilience, Plans de Mobilité Employeur); institutional actors (local authorities, mobility agencies, intercommunal authorities); and existing solutions (MaaS platforms, gamification tools, incentive mechanisms).

3.3. Field research and interviews

Interviews were conducted with institutional actors (local governments, regional mobility networks) and mobility experts. These exchanges tested working hypotheses against real-world governance and decision-making practices, and generated the primary material for the territorial case studies of Perpignan, Bourges, Auxerre, Rennes, and Bordeaux.

3.4. Territorial analysis

Priority territories for potential deployment were identified on the basis of multi-criteria assessment: political commitment to sustainable mobility, governance structure, local mobility culture, and partnership opportunities. The framework deliberately privileged mid-sized cities over major metropolitan agglomerations, where mobility ecosystems are dense, contested, and dominated by established actors.

4. Findings and Analysis

4.1. The strategic gap: infrastructure without engagement

The central finding of the exploratory phase is structural. The French sustainable-mobility market is highly institutionalised, with local authorities and mobility agencies acting as gatekeepers for any large-scale deployment. Infrastructure, regulation, and incentives have matured significantly. Yet the tools capable of mobilising individual users, sustaining their engagement over time, and translating policy ambitions into lived practices remain scarce, fragmented, and short-lived.

Infrastructure enables sustainable mobility choices without motivating them. Regulation creates obligations without producing enthusiasm. Incentives reduce friction without building habits. The gap is relational and behavioural.

4.2. Governance and engagement: a structural separation

Decision-making power is concentrated among institutional actors — municipalities, mobility departments, intercommunal authorities, and public-transport authorities — while behavioural change is expected from users who have limited agency over system design.

Many mobility initiatives consequently struggle to translate policy objectives into sustained participation.

For MUV, this configuration carries two implications. Successful deployment requires early and close collaboration with institutional stakeholders. Long-term impact depends on the ability to activate peripheral actors and users, transforming them from passive beneficiaries into active participants.

4.3. Gamification: underutilised and underembedded

Gamification-based solutions exist in France, and yet their long-term impact remains limited. The analysis shows that gamification is predominantly used as a short-term activation tool — rarely embedded in long-term behavioural strategies, and insufficiently connected to real everyday practices. Once a challenge ends, behaviour typically reverts.

MUV's strength lies in the intensity of the experiences it generates: tournaments, teams, and competitive roles produce CO₂ reductions of 32–36% during the campaign window (validated against ISO 14064-2). The limitation, in the French context, is the difficulty of converting these spikes into continuous engagement.

4.4. Operational barriers

Barriers to adoption are strategic and operational in equal measure. Complexity of GPS tracking, limited clarity during onboarding, and insufficient visibility of engagement in daily life reduce the application's ability to integrate into users' routines. Rennes explicitly raised the issue of 'app fatigue' — residents already use multiple mobility applications, making the addition of a standalone tool a non-trivial barrier.

4.5. MUV's strategic positioning

MUV's solution architecture is designed precisely to occupy the engagement layer the French ecosystem lacks. It articulates four components: a Survey module for collecting baseline mobility data; a Dashboard with AI-assisted analytics for monitoring Scope 3 indicators; the MUV Game itself for active engagement; and a Report module for producing sustainability reports compliant with European standards.

This integrated structure distinguishes MUV from purely playful gamification tools on the one hand, and purely infrastructural reporting platforms on the other. The French market contains direct competitors — Squadeasy, Mobeelity, Moovance, Geovelo — and none successfully bridge system-level integration and sustained behavioural engagement. This is MUV's strategic opening.

5. The Chosen Solution: A Dual-Track Market Entry Strategy

5.1. Overall logic

Three tensions structured the strategic reasoning: standalone application versus integration layer; B2G institutional anchoring versus B2B market activation; and short-term activation versus long-term habit formation. Rather than resolving these tensions by selecting a single channel or model, the project converged on a dual-track hypothesis articulating two complementary approaches designed to address different layers of the gap.

The institutional track produces the political and territorial conditions within which future deployments can scale. The community track produces the operational and methodological evidence that institutional partners need to commit. The two tracks are designed to inform each other.

5.2. Track A — Institutional anchoring through municipal partnerships

Structured dialogue was initiated with five French cities, selected on the basis of the multi-criteria territorial framework. Each city presents a distinct strategic anchor:

- Perpignan — the most advanced dialogue, closest to a formal pilot agreement. The city frames its priority as ‘image work’: making alternative mobility feel real, modern, and desirable. Game mechanics have not previously been considered as mobility-policy levers, and the city reacted positively to the proposition. Principal constraint: an approaching election period.
- Bourges — structured around the city’s designation as European Capital of Culture 2028, which generates a series of mobility needs mapping closely onto MUV’s value proposition: low-carbon visitor mobility, peak-flow management, intermodal integration, and credible carbon quantification.
- Auxerre — anchored in an ongoing ecological urban transformation, including the development of an eco-district (construction permits issued, full realisation by 2030). The city’s representative suggested deployment at city scale, ahead of neighbourhood-level rollout, to begin producing measurable effects immediately.
- Rennes — a technically substantive conversation, deferred pending post-election leadership. The exchange centred on interoperability and Open API integration: the proposed collaboration would allow partner applications to certify trips and feed data to MUV, with no requirement for users to track in MUV directly.
- Bordeaux — an introductory contact. Strategically attractive given mature mobility governance and active cycling culture, though too early to characterise a precise scope.

A cross-cutting observation: political timing recurs across all territories as a structural constraint on the rhythm of institutional commitment. There is no single ‘French municipal market’ — deployment strategy must be calibrated city by city, on the basis of each territory’s distinct framing, governance structure, and electoral calendar.

5.3. Track B — Community pilot at Sciences Po

In parallel, a pilot tournament was launched within the Sciences Po Impact Studio community, running from 23 March to 10 May 2026. Teams were formed on the basis of pre-existing professional and disciplinary affiliations, lowering the social cost of participation.

A tournament format was retained over a more open-ended challenge format, on the basis that the weekly match structure produces stronger engagement dynamics and clearer narrative momentum across the seven-week window. The incentive structure combines collective and individual rewards — Vélib’ subscriptions, curated mobility kits, and official certificates — with Vélib’ chosen deliberately to link tournament participation to tangible mobility infrastructure.

5.4. Communication design as a strategic methodology

The communication ecosystem surrounding the Sciences Po pilot — developed in a shared Figma workspace — represents the most directly transferable methodological contribution of this phase. Communication was treated as a strategic instrument conditioning adoption, retention, and the perceived legitimacy of the platform within its host community — upstream of deployment, woven into it.

Two newsletters illustrate the approach: the pre-launch communication (20 March 2026) introduced MUV by foregrounding its underlying logic without overburdening the reader with technical detail, anchored legitimacy within an institutional partnership, and activated pre-existing group identities through the listing of participating teams. The launch-day communication (23 March 2026) shifted register from anticipation to activation, converting passive interest into onboarding by reducing the joining process to a four-step sequence.

6. Conclusion

This project confirms a central paradox: while sustainable mobility policies in France are becoming increasingly structured and ambitious, their impact remains limited by the absence of tools capable of engaging individuals over time. Within this gap, MUV holds a strong strategic opportunity to act as an intermediary layer between systems and behaviours — bridging institutional objectives and lived experiences.

Three takeaways structure the path forward. First, the French sustainable-mobility market is best understood as a layered architecture in which infrastructure, regulation, and incentives have matured significantly while the engagement and motivation layer remain comparatively underdeveloped — the strategic opportunity for MUV lies in occupying this complementary position. Second, communication design is a precondition for product–market fit, demanding investment from the outset. Third, establishing institutional credibility as a foreign entrant is above all a relational challenge — trust is constructed through patient, situated engagement with institutional interlocutors.

Seizing this opportunity requires a key shift: from a standalone application logic to an integration-driven approach, embedded within local ecosystems and everyday practices. More than a technological tool, MUV has the potential to become a driver of behavioural transformation — provided it successfully combines engagement, simplicity, and territorial relevance.

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